WILDLIFE DISEASES

Situation Report Q4/25

Period covered: Aug – Dec 2025

This report provides an update of wildlife disease situation, according to the information submitted on listed diseases through the World Animal Health Information System of the World Organisation for Animal Health (WAHIS).

A general introduction of the scope and objective of this report as well as global level of wildlife disease surveillance activities can be found on Wildlife Health - WOAH - World Organisation for Animal Health.

Key messages and Recommendations

- During the reporting period, **52 countries and territories** reported **6,000outbreaks** and **9,224 cases of WOAH listed diseases** in wildlife. Cases related to **9 diseases** were reported in **193 different wildlife species, 15%** of which are classified as being at **risk of extinction** by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List.

- The reporting of exceptional events affecting wildlife during this period was mainly concerned with **African swine fever (ASF)** and **highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI)** in several regions. This situation has also been observed in previous reports, and indirectly shows the widespread surveillance of these two specific diseases by WOAH members, not to mention their extensive worldwide distribution. All other diseases recorded a relatively low number of outbreaks.

- Deaths and cases in **28 threatened species** have been reported, representing **3% of the total number of cases** notified during the period. The spread and persistence of ASF and HPAI in wildlife pose a threat not only to biodiversity (especially when the diseases are reported in fragmented and threatened avian and mammal populations), but also to livestock health, food security, and human health at a global level. In particular, HPAI affected 21 threatened species, including several species classified as Endangered or Critically Endangered.

- During this period, two other diseases played a significant role in terms of impact on biodiversity: Anthrax, which affected five threatened species in Mozambique, including the Critically Endangered African Forest Elephant and the Vulnerable Hippopotamus and Lion; and *Echinococcus granulosus*, which affected one Vulnerable species (Mouflon) in Cyprus. In addition, bluetongue (BT) affected two threatened wild sheep species in Europe, including the Vulnerable Mouflon and the Near Threatened Argali.

- From a public health perspective, it is important to highlight that during the period, five out of the nine diseases reported are classified as zoonoses. In addition to the continued reporting of HPAI in wildlife, notable public health events included the first occurrence of rabies in a zone in Kazakhstan and the first occurrence of West Nile Fever (WNF) in Belgium.

Recent updates (August – December 2025)

In total, **6,000 new outbreaks** with **9,224 cases** of exceptional disease events in terrestrial wildlife (based on the criteria listed in Article 1.1.3. of WOAH *Terrestrial Animal Health Code* - Figure 1) were notified to the World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH) during the reporting period, through the World Animal Health Information System (WAHIS). Other cases in wildlife have been reported during the period via email according to the provision of article 1.1.5 of the *Terrestrial Animal Health Code,* and related information can be consulted in the dedicated dashboard, not being part of this report. This report does not include cases in wild animals from areas where the disease situation is declared as stable, as well as diseases that do not appear among WOAH-listed diseases.

Outbreaks were reported in Africa, in the Americas, in Asia, and in Europe for nine diseases (see Figures 1 and 2). Specifically, Members reported **infection with African swine fever virus (ASF), Anthrax, infection with Aujeszky's disease virus, infection with bluetongue virus (BT), *E. granulosus*, Heartwater, infection of birds other than poultry—including wild birds—with influenza A viruses of high pathogenicity (HPAI), infection with rabies virus (rabies), and West Nile Fever (WNF).**

As shown in Figure 2, most outbreaks (98%) were reported in Europe, possibly because of more extensive wildlife surveillance or reporting activities. Most of the outbreaks reported in all the regions were associated with the presence or spread of HPAI. The diseases with the highest global number of outbreaks reported were, as in previous reports, HPAI (3,683 outbreaks) and ASF (2,281 outbreaks).

Cases of these diseases were reported in 193 different wild species belonging to 25 orders (see Tables 1 and 2).

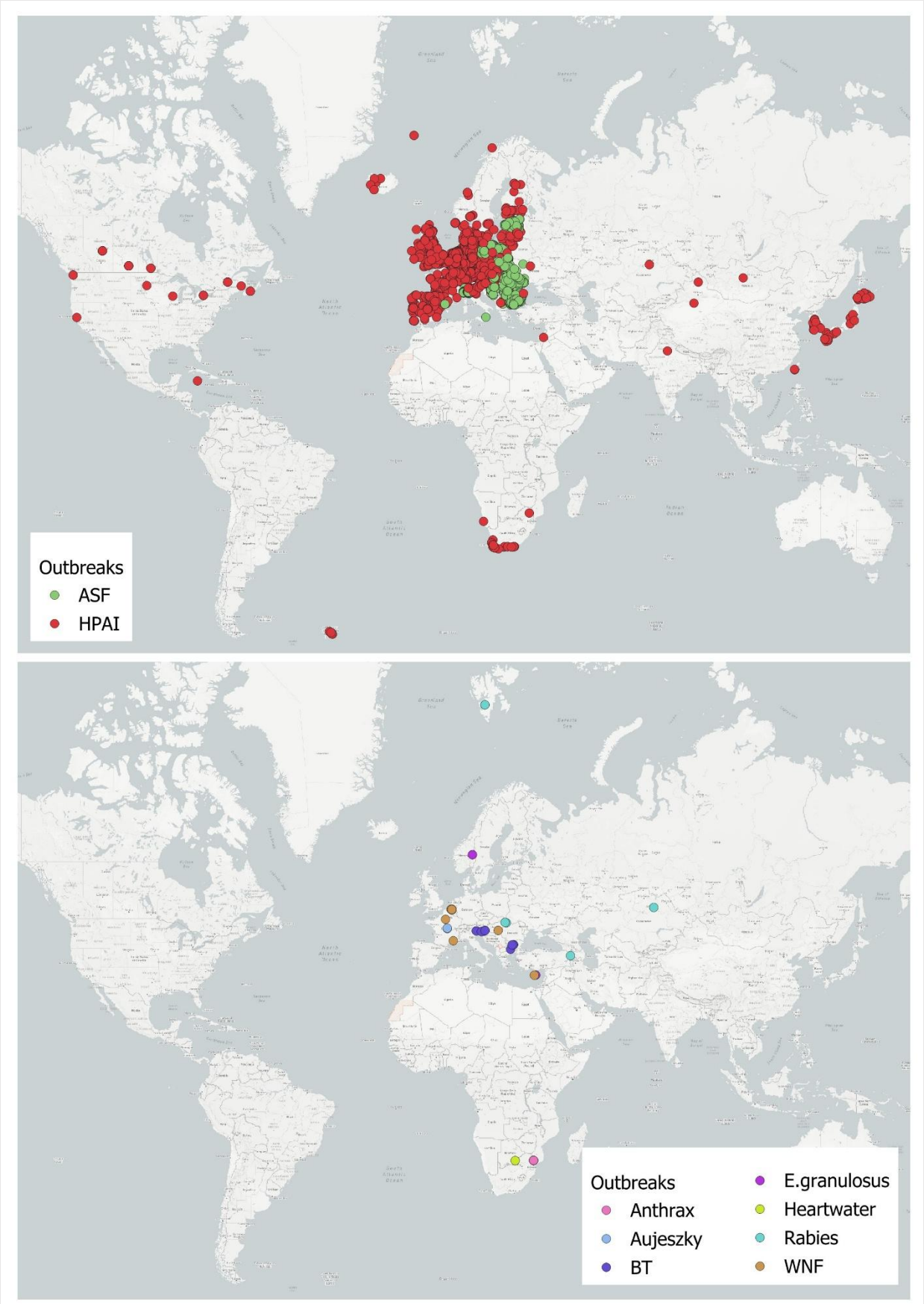


Figure 1. New outbreaks of exceptional disease events reported during the period in terrestrial wildlife. Due to the large number of their outbreaks, ASF and HPAI are presented in a separate map (ASF = infection with African swine fever virus; BT = infection with bluetongue virus; HPAI = Infection of birds other than poultry, including wild birds, with influenza A viruses of high pathogenicity; WNF = West Nile fever).

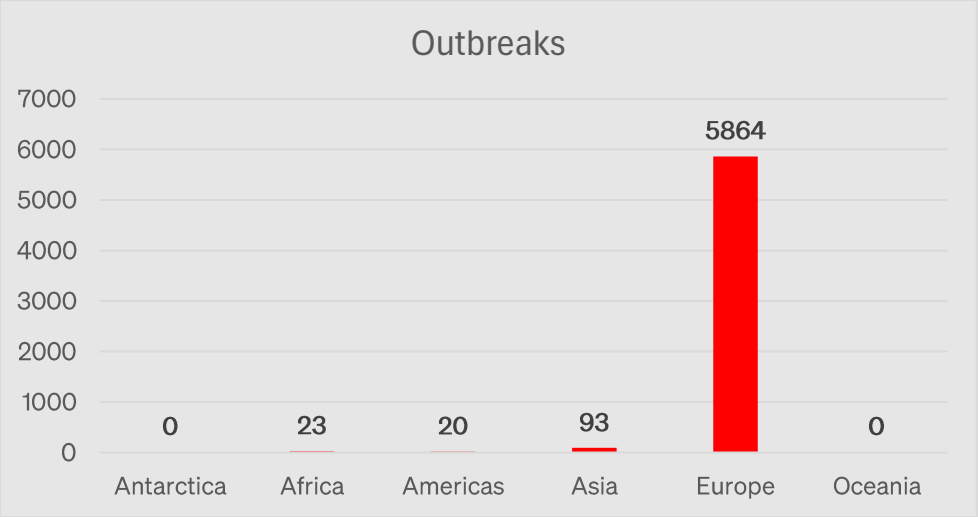


Figure 2. Number of outbreaks reported during the period by world region.

Table 1. Number of outbreaks reported by disease and information on zoonotic character of the disease[1].

Disease	Outbreaks reported	Zoonotic disease
ASF	2281	No
Anthrax	1	Common
Aujeszky	2	No
BT	14	No
E. granulosus	2	Common
Heartwater	1	No
HPAI	3683	Common
Rabies	5	Common
WNF	11	Common

Table 2. Number of cases reported by order, and animal species; conservation status of each species, based on IUCN Red List of threatened species (database accessed on 06 July 2025). This table provides the diseases that affected species with threatened status. The full list of species reported is available on demand.

Disease	Cases	Species (common name)	Reporting countries/ territories	Conservation Status *
Anthrax	9	African buffalo (Cape buffalo)	Mozambique	NT
Anthrax	1	African Forest Elephant	Mozambique	CR
Anthrax	1	Hippopotamus	Mozambique	VU
Anthrax	1	Lion	Mozambique	VU
Anthrax	1	Plains Zebra	Mozambique	NT
BT	1	Argali	Slovenia	NT
BT	2	Mouflon	Bulgaria, Italy	VU

[1] This assessment is based on the definition of zoonosis documented in the Tripartite Guide to Addressing Zoonotic Diseases in Countries: "infectious diseases that can be spread between animals and humans; can be spread by food, water, fomites, or vectors."

Disease	Cases	Species (common name)	Reporting countries/ territories	Conservation Status *
E. granulosus	1	Mouflon	Cyprus	VU
HPAI	1	Andaman Wood-Pigeon	Belgium	NT
HPAI	1	Black-faced spoonbill	Chinese Taipei	EN
HPAI	1	Blakiston's fish owl	Japan	EN
HPAI	2	Cape cormorant	South Africa	EN
HPAI	1	Common Eider	Denmark	NT
HPAI	4	Common Pochard	Switzerland, Italy	VU
HPAI	6	Eurasian Curlew	Italy, United Kingdom, Netherlands, Sweden	NT
HPAI	1	Greater Rhea	Spain	NT
HPAI	1	Greater Spotted Eagle	Sweden	VU
HPAI	10	Hooded crane	Japan	VU
HPAI	10	Jackass Penguin	South Africa	EN
HPAI	1	Lesser white-fronted goose	Korea (Rep of)	VU
HPAI	2	Nene	Czech Republic	NT
HPAI	19	Painted stork	India	NT
HPAI	4	Red-crowned Crane	Japan	VU
HPAI	1	Redwing	Belgium	NT
HPAI	1	Waldrapp	Portugal	EN
HPAI	1	West Indian Whistling-Duck	Cayman Islands	NT
HPAI	2	White-backed Vulture	South Africa	CR
HPAI	1	White-naped crane	Japan	VU
HPAI	2	Whooping Crane	Canada, United States of America	EN

*NT=Near threatened; VU=vulnerable; EN= endangered; CR= critically endangered

Global and regional impact

Reporting and impact on biodiversity

Out of the 193 wild species for which cases were reported, 28 (15%) have a threatened status according to the IUCN classification. They constitute 3% of cases reported in wildlife over the period. Species threatened with extinction are less numerous and rely on a limited geographic distribution, and therefore, their population may not recover from a significant disease outbreak. Two species are classified as Critically Endangered (CR), six species are classified as "Endangered" (EN), ten as "Vulnerable" (VU), and 11 as "Near threatened" (NT) (see Figure 3 and Table 2). In light of their status, the fact that they are affected by diseases with high mortality rate is extremely concerning.

Of the 9 diseases reported, HPAI is the one that affected the highest number of threatened species (21 out of 28), Anthrax affected five, BT affected two and *E. granulosus* affected one species.

The detection of HPAI in species with a vulnerable conservation status is a common and consistent finding in our analysis, highlighting the potentially detrimental impact of this disease on biodiversity conservation, due to additional mortality. Further scientific studies, such as a longitudinal wildlife population assessment, would be needed to measure the impact of the disease on these population.

West Nile Virus (WNV) is endemic in Western Europe, with wild birds acting as primary reservoirs, facilitating spread and periodic outbreaks. Recent years show intensified circulation of lineage 2, with significant detections in corvids and raptors in Germany, Spain, and Belgium's first cases in 2025 included in this report.

Raptors and corvids (crows, jays) are often heavily impacted, showing neurological symptoms and high mortality. In addition to determining the adverse impact on wild bird populations, surveillance serves as an early warning system for human exposure risk. The presence of the virus in birds often precedes outbreaks in horses and humans during mosquito season.

Usutu virus, a closely related flavivirus also transmitted by mosquitoes, shares the same avian hosts as WNV. USUV has caused massive die-offs in European blackbird and owl populations across Germany, Belgium, and the Netherlands. Because WNV and USUV antibodies cross-react in basic screening tests, laboratories now use highly specific virus neutralisation tests to distinguish which virus a bird was exposed.

Insight from the WOAH Working Group on Wildlife

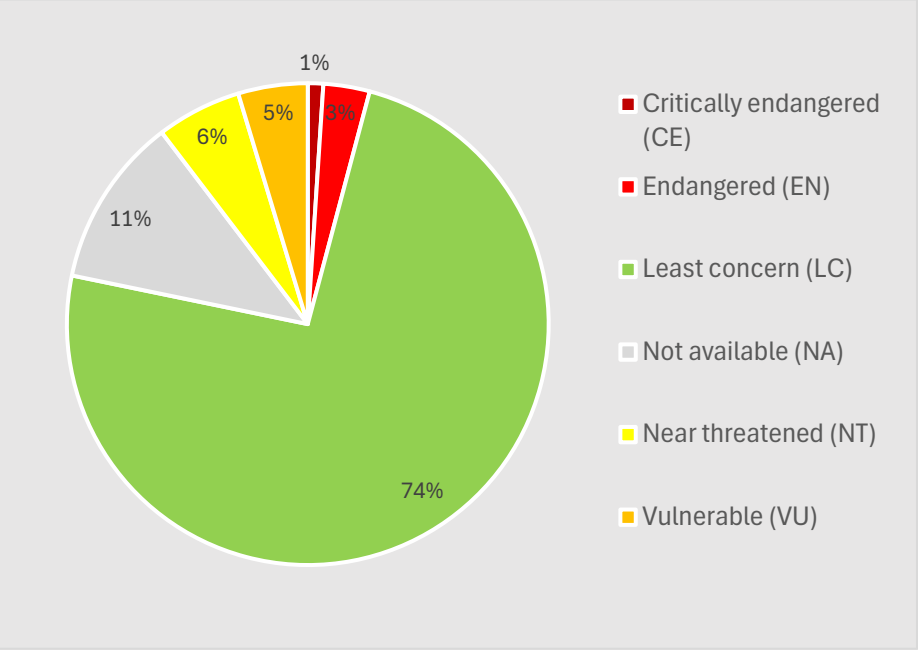


Figure 3. Percentage of reported species falling under the different IUCN categories.

Considering only species with "Critically Endangered (CR)" IUCN status, Anthrax was detected in one wild African Forest Elephant in Mozambique and HPAI in two White-backed Vulture in South Africa. To provide an idea of the potential impact of Anthrax and HPAI occurrence in these species, it is relevant to highlight that:

- The populations of African Forest Elephant have declined by more than 80% over recent decades, primarily driven by intensive poaching for ivory and widespread habitat loss. Current estimates suggest fewer than 150,000 individuals remain globally. The species is distributed across the tropical forests of West and Central Africa, with its stronghold in the Congo Basin. However, its current area of presence is highly fragmented, with many remaining populations isolated in protected areas. Ongoing pressures from logging, agricultural expansion, and infrastructure development continue to degrade and reduce its habitat. As a result, both population size and connectivity are still decreasing across most of its presence area.

- White-backed Vultures have undergone rapid and widespread population declines across Africa, largely driven by poisoning (both intentional and incidental), habitat loss, and reductions in available food sources. While precise global numbers are uncertain, the population has declined by an estimated 63–89% over the last few decades, with earlier estimates of hundreds of thousands now greatly reduced. The species is widely distributed across sub-Saharan Africa, mainly in savannah and open woodland ecosystems. However, its current range is increasingly fragmented, with populations becoming more concentrated in protected areas. Ongoing threats, particularly poisoning linked to poaching and human–wildlife conflict, continue to drive a sustained population decline.

In both the examples diseases can increase the stress of the population with additional mortality.

Reporting and impact on public health

HPAI has a recognised zoonotic potential, and the disease is by far the most reported one in term of outbreaks in wild birds. In addition, the number of cases in mammals has increased in the past years meaning the virus has adapted to infect mammals more efficiently. This situation is worrying from a public health perspective. Cases in mammalian species are reported through article 1.1.5 dedicated dashboard here. The increased number of HPAI cases reported in mammals is a trend observed since 2021 (for additional information, see the HPAI situation reports). This trend has led to: i) a statement of WOAH on avian influenza in mammals to increase awareness, monitoring and analysis of wild mammals, acknowledging the risk that H5N1 avian influenza may increasingly adapt to mammals; and ii) a statement on the impact of HPAI on wildlife worldwide that warns that the global spread of highly pathogenic avian influenza (HPAI) H5 viruses is causing unprecedented wildlife mortality, biodiversity loss, and ecological disruption worldwide, calling for urgent, coordinated One Health action.

Some outbreaks of the other common zoonoses (anthrax, *E. granulosus*, rabies, WNF) were reported in eight countries (Armenia, Belgium, Cyprus, France, Hungary, Kazakhstan, Mozambique, Norway).

From a public health perspective, it is worth mentioning the first occurrence of rabies in a zone in Kazakhstan, and the first occurrence of WNF in Belgium.

Reporting and impact on domestic animal health and welfare

During the reporting period, most of the outbreaks of non-zoonotic diseases were related to the occurrence of **ASF in wild boars** in Europe and Asia. ASF is one of the major animal diseases currently threatening global livestock and food security (for more information, see the ASF situation reports). A recent publication highlights that 39% of infected wild boars populations originated from outbreak farms, and 61% from other infected wild boar populations, with favourable habitat exhibiting higher susceptibility and infectivity than unfavourable habitats.

Regarding the occurrence of **HPAI**, the dynamics of the disease at the poultry/wildlife interface can also impact food security (for additional information see the HPAI situation reports).

More information and resources

- Statement on avian influenza and mammals
- Avian Influenza and Wildlife: Risk Management for People Working with Wild Birds
- Continued expansion of HPAI H5 in wildlife in South America and incursion into the Antarctic region (OFFLU statement)
- Considerations for emergency vaccination of wild birds against high pathogenicity avian influenza in specific situations
- African swine fever in wild boar ecology and biosecurity
- African swine fever awareness and technical resources
- In-country wildlife disease surveillance report 2021
- In-country wildlife data management survey dashboard 2023

For any press inquiry on diseases in wildlife, you can email us at media@woah.org

Complete list of species for which cases were reported in this report is available on demand at epi@woah.org.

To contact the wildlife team at WOAH use wildlife@woah.org.